

Wasting Time?

Reflections on digital technology's affective grip

The view that digital media are addictive and manipulative devices has become common-sensical by now. It is the image of digital control in which by means of datafication people's emotional pressure points and desires are observed and targeted by algorithmic systems to bind people affectively to devices and platforms.

Rendering time spent using digital media as meaningful has therefore become if not impossible at least an intellectually infeasible task today.

The claim of digital technology's affective grip is present everywhere in-between everyday life observations and academic monographs. Be it in form of ideas of social media as 'grand radicalisers' (Tufekci 2018) or 'emotion machines' (Sampson et al. 2018), in yet to be proofed diagnoses of growing isolation, depression, and anxiety (Orben 2019), or in cultural movements of digital disconnection (Karppi 2018) and digital detox (Sutton 2017).

Humanist

v

Post-humanist

At its most radical, a humanist reading of the digital sees it as **inevitably lacking compared to 'real' human encounters and experiences.**

Variations of this stance argue lasting relationships only to be found offline (Turkle 2011), observe an inchoate sense that online sociality is lacking something important (Couldry and van Dijck 2015), or study well-being in set behavioural terms, rendering digital media as addictive dopamine machines (Haynes 2018).

From a humanist point of view time spent using digital media is wasted because it is lacking. It **can, if at all, only function as supplement to 'the real'** moments of meaningful human encounter.

A post-humanist reading emphasises that **technologies are, and always have been, constitutive in the process of personal and communal becoming.** It decentralises 'the human' to in turn understand the importance of 'other-than human' entities.

Herein post-humanism (Hayles 2012, Parisi 2013, Hansen 2015, Clough 2018) often takes a universalising view, talks a 'digital condition', often rendering actual contexts of use as merely residual.

Focussing on **criticising predominant capitalist** and extractive natures of **media environments, post-humanist thought too consolidates pessimistic assessment** of 'the digital'.

Enacting digital media use as meaningful practice, as time not wasted, is in parts a matter of charting epistemic grounds adequate to the object observed. It is a question of the language used to enunciate a 'positioned truth' (Ang 1996) about the digital world.

A humanist perspective is ultimately defensive of an established idea of the 'good life'. A post-humanist reading takes a universalising view, closing all doors of change until it can only offer disconnection as solution to domains of digital control.

In-between these two epistemic grounds, often overlooked or seldom named as such, sits that of post-sociality (Knorr-Cetina 1997). It takes an interactionist view on how people engage with technology. This is important as it fixes the problem of humanist inquiry - only deeming human-human encounters of value - and that of post-humanist universalism.

Video hosting service founded in 2012, acquired by Twitter.

End of service in late 2016, hinging behind innovations of Instagram and Snapchat.



Create, upload, and share six-second long looping videos, so called “Vines”.

200M+ active users at the end of 2015.

vines that keep me from ending it all

vines that butter my croissant

vines that i quote daily

vines that cured my cancer

vines that keep me alive



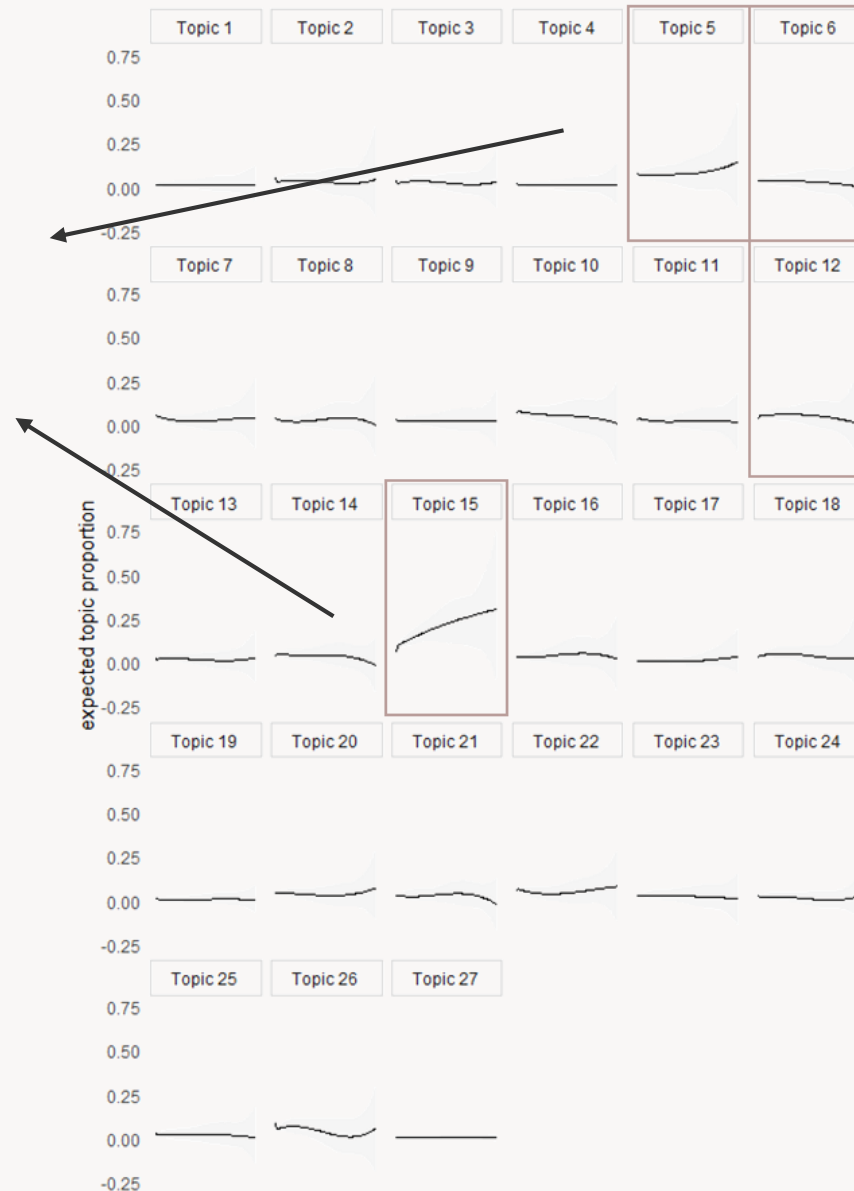
vines that cured my depression clean

vines that are cleaner than your grandma's kitchen

vines that really butter my croissant

vines that toast my buns

Topics that tend to have a higher centrality are core video montages concerning the search query (topics 5 and 15). Most are titled and tagged with 'funny', 'happiness', 'cured me', 'keep me alive', 'laugh'.



Topics 6 and 12 feature similar montages, however have lower centrality. They are titled and tagged with terms like 'depression', 'lost control of life', 'medium rare', 'underrated', 'think about'.

Moral panics and fears have always surrounded the moments when media technologies were introduced as historically new (Marvin 1988). Likewise patronising (humanist) and universalising (post-humanist) assessments on the consequences of media have been criticised widely already in the 1980s.

Humanist and post-humanist critiques, justify the observation of digital media environments as lacking, are politically relevant today. However, do these epistemic grounds really allow us to cover the full image on the digital and its myths?

Taking cues from 1980s cultural studies – taking the popular seriously (Hall 1981) and being interested in culture as a social process (Ang 1990) – to understand the post-social, human-machine relationships that shape our everyday life offers a promising alternative I argue.

Thanks!

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